

The WWW is lost

My first memory of the internet is from 1997-98. And back then, the World Wide Web still felt appropriately named – because it was definitely wide, slightly wild, and something you had to travel through from your PC's monitor screen.

At that time, only about 3% of the world was online and Google's first web index contained only 26 million pages. By 2000, that index had crossed the one billion mark. The web wasn't merely expanding or growing, it felt like a new continent being discovered in real-time, and everyone connected to it felt like pioneering explorers.

Using the internet back then required effort. You searched, scrolled, clicked and opened five links until you finally found what you were looking for. It didn't always work perfectly, but the journey was the destination, while exploring different corners of the WWW.

Friction was a big part of every aspect of the early internet. Dial-up connections were slow, HTML pages broke, Google search didn't feel like it could read your mind yet. But that friction was worth it. In your quest of curiosity to explore the internet, one didn't just retrieve information as much as encounter it. A hyperlink wasn't a citation, like it is today, but an opportunity to see what someone else had built online. You wandered past things online before finding what you were looking for.

Pretty soon, we stopped going out, as the web started coming to us. Social media, smartphones and apps gradually placed a layer between us and the open internet. Google still sent us out into websites, but Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, YouTube and other apps started to train us to stay inside their walls. The destination became the feed.

The internet didn't disappear as much as it started to get controlled by intermediaries.

Video accelerated that shrinking. Instead of seeking out a website, reading pages and following links, we started waiting for information to find us – through recommendations, reels and algorithmically selected explainer.



“First, apps reduced the number of places we visit. Then feeds reduced the number of things we sought. Now AI is reducing the need to visit at all.”

Jayesh Shinde
Executive Editor



Let me know your thoughts on this column at:
jayesh.shinde@digit.in | @jshinde

And now AI is taking this logic to its natural, slightly terrifying conclusion. Where search engines once helped you find answers, AI chatbots increasingly want to be the answer.

Pew found that when Google showed an AI summary, users clicked a traditional search result in just 8% of visits, versus 15% when no summary appeared. Links cited inside the AI summary itself were clicked only 1% of the time. What's being embraced as convenience on an industrial scale is removing the journey of finding something on the internet when it began all those years ago.

We are watching the internet journey getting inverted in real-time. Questions that were once asked in public forum threads as part of a shared human knowledge bank for all, those same questions are increasingly being asked inside AI interfaces, behind closed doors.

There is an economic consequence of the disappearance of the internet of old. According to Cloudflare's June 2025 estimate, Google roughly crawled about 14 pages for every referral it sent to websites – that same ratio for OpenAI was about 1,700:1 and for Anthropic it was 73,000:1. There's no incentive to run a website online, because the rise of AI is ensuring it won't get any traffic.

Before you dismiss me off as an anti-AI keyboard warrior, you're mistaken. Everyday I use AI, and I'm grateful for what it does.

Something is being lost when every layer of progress removes another reason to explore the open web. First, apps reduced the number of places we visit. Then feeds reduced the number of things we sought. Now AI is reducing the need to visit at all.

Maybe the internet isn't dying, maybe it's becoming invisible, as it was ultimately meant to be. Because, technically, the internet and World Wide Web will need to exist even if the AI layer prevents us from visiting often. Not being able to revisit that journey of typing something in a browser and not knowing what you'd find by the end of that session, that definitely fills me with a sense of grief. **d**